4.3.3 Never commit early unless you know why

The third principle of Real Options is simply to defer committing to a particular solution ("exercising the option") until you know enough about why you're choosing that solution.

Real Options gives you the possibility to put off making a decision, but the aim is not to systematically delay until the last possible (or "responsible") moment. Using Real Options, you only delay until you have enough information to act. When you have enough information, you implement your chosen solution as quickly as possible. For example, you may be delaying your decision because solution A is being developed by another team, and you want to wait to see if this library will work well in your situation. In this case, you can wait until the option for solution A expires, but no longer. If the library takes longer than this to develop, you'll be forced to exclude solution A from your list of options.

But you may choose to act sooner if you can. For example, if your team could build either solution A or solution B, but you don't know which is the most appropriate, you might choose to build experimental versions of both solutions concurrently. If you obtain enough information to act before the options expire, it makes sense to act sooner rather than later.

To help you learn enough to make sensible design and implementation decisions, you can use an approach called Deliberate Discovery.

4.4 Deliberate Discovery

Deliberate Discovery is the flip side of Real Options, and the two principles go hand in hand. Deliberate Discovery was originally proposed by Dan North[5] and was developed by Liz Keogh and other members of the London BDD community.

In software development, ignorance is the constraint. You know a lot more about the best way to build a particular solution after you've finished building it, but by then it's too late to take advantage of your knowledge. You can use the principles of Real Options to put off choosing a particular implementation, or implementing a particular feature or story, until you know enough to make a reasonable decision. But if you're aware that you don't know what the best solution is, you can proactively investigate your options in order to make a reasonable decision sooner rather than later. Uncertainty represents risk, and where possible you should hunt out and reduce uncertainty. This is where Deliberate Discovery steps in.

Deliberate Discovery starts with the assumption that there are things you don't know. This might be something bad that you couldn't possibly have anticipated and that will pop up and cause you problems at some point during the project. Or it might be an opportunity to innovate: "If only we'd known about that technology earlier, we could have built this feature in half the time."

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[5] Dan North, "Introducing Deliberate Discovery" (2010), http://dannorth.net/2010/08/30/introducing-deliberate-discovery.